triggering the Rebellion. What is worse is that the conduct of the British in putting down the Rebellion had religious bigotry written all over it. While the Muslims among the rebels were sewed in pigskins smeared with pork fat before execution, after which their bodies were burnt, the Hindus were forced to defile themselves by consuming beef. As for the civilian population, the conduct of English troops should have denuded the British of the authority to hold forth on ‘civilisation’ for eternity. Thousands of civilians were massacred and villages that were suspected of helping the Indian Rebels were destroyed with the men being slaughtered and the women being subjected to all forms of sexual violence. Clearly, the unprovoked massacre at Jallianwala Bagh was not an aberration and not without precedent. The role played by the European coloniser’s utter contempt for the natives, their religion and race must not be ruled out as a contributing factor to the barbarity and savagery meted out to the rebels and the civilian population.

While the origin of the Rebellion is usually traced to Meerut in May 1857, according to some scholars it began on 23 January 1857 at Dumdum near Calcutta, which spread to Barrackpore in March, Ambala in April, and Meerut, Lucknow and Delhi in May. ‘Peace’ was restored in November 1858; however, the Company was blamed for the Rebellion and the manner of its handling. By December 1857, Henry John Temple (‘Lord Palmerston’), the then British prime minister, informed the Company that a Bill would soon be introduced in the British Parliament to abolish the Company and transfer all territories of British India and the Government of India itself to the Crown. Naturally, the Company begged and pleaded and even pitched its case through the philosopher and politician John Stuart Mill, but to no avail. On 12 February 1858, Lord Palmerston introduced the Bill in the British Parliament to end the dual government of the Company and the Crown. He lamented that ‘the management of such extensive territories, such vast interests, and such numerous populations’ had been ‘deliberately consigned to the care of a small body of commercial men’. Excoriating the Company, he said[3]:

> The principle of our political system is that all administrative functions should be accompanied by ministerial responsibility—responsibility to Parliament, responsibility to public opinion, responsibility to the Crown; but in this case the chief functions in the government of India